

Chemical Engineering External Advisory Board Meeting Minutes

October 2, 2026, 1:00pm-4:00pm

Engineering Innovation Building EIB 224

Attendees:

EAB Board: Saadet Acikgoz, Shailendra Bordawekar, Tarun Chandra, Claus Daniel, Soundar Kumaran, Kyle Kostroski

Faculty: Vivek Sharma, Vikas Berry, Alan Zdunek, Brian Chaplin, Said Al-Hallaj, Meenesh Singh, Michael Caracotsio, Korosh Torabi, Betul Bilgin, Lew Wedgewood, Ying Liu, Christos Takoudis, Roshan Nemade

Meeting Minutes from September 2025 reviewed

State of the Department presentation (Sharma):

- New Interim Head of Department, Vivek Sharma introduced; Vikas Berry, former head, recognized for his a10+ years of accomplishments as past Head of the Department.
- Undergraduate enrollment has increased from 2025 (188 → 218)
- Graduate enrollment and research funding are holding steady from last year
- **UIC Catalyst (CAT) Center:** Meenesh Singh gave an update on the summit held in May 2026. There are over 25 industrial partners collaborating with the Center, with four active workgroups. Shailendra asked if the company-sponsored projects are mostly fundamental, and how we handle IP issues from joint projects; Meenesh stated that the projects are a mix of fundamental and applied research, and we have a provision for the company to retain their IP, and exclusivity to potential new IP can be offered to the sponsor. Meenesh stated that there was a strong interest in the UIC CAT model among other universities. Meenesh has been invited to present the CAT initiative at the AIChE meeting in November, and previously presented the CAT model at the University Industry Demonstration Partnership (UIDP).

Undergraduate Program presentation (Zdunek):

- Overview of recruitment efforts and new initiatives to increase enrollments

ABET Review Update and Program Educational Objectives

- Update on the ABET review (November 15-17); Self-study report sent out July 2026.
- Showed the ABET Presentation System to the board which contains the additional information needed for the ABET visit in November.
- Presented the process for revising the ChE Mission Statement and Program Educational Objectives (PEOs): Faculty review, EAB review, alumni review, student review.
- Discussed the revised Mission Statement and PEO's with comments incorporated into the statements.
 - **Action Item:** Send PEO's back to Board for one final review and approval.

Graduate Program presentation (Chaplin):

- Updates on graduate student enrollment
- Recruiting concerns- how to effectively recruit from foreign countries
- How to grow our MS programs

Industry Integrated MS program

- Create a chemical engineering MS pathway designed for practicing engineers
 - Working engineers who want deeper technical capability but still work
 - Industry seeking workforce development tied to real technical problems
 - Modeled after existing programs from other universities
- Build with industry rather than marketing it to industry
- Leverage UIC location, Chicago industrial ecosystem, and our MS infrastructure

Discussion points during meeting:

- Night courses would be needed
- IP related issues with industry projects
- Add cross-disciplinary engineering courses, project management courses instead of economics, AI-related courses to curriculum
- Questions for EAB members:
 - Would your company support employees pursuing this degree part-time?
 - What technical areas would create the most value?
 - Would you provide Capstone Problems and industry mentors?
 - How important are evening, hybrid, or online options?
 - What would differentiate this from an MBA or conventional MS?
 - What barriers (IP, confidentiality, tuition, employee time) must we solve?
- **Action Items:**
 - Send the above questions to EAB members as a Google survey
 - Organize a workforce group of EAB members and industry partners to assess demand and shape the program.